
SESSION 3D

WORSHIP

DESIRING HEAVEN

Frankly, many of us find it difficult to desire heaven in a robust way. The biblical pictures of heaven—a square city with a glass sea; a pure bride beautifully dressed for her groom; sapphires and pearls—do not readily conjure up a coherent or compelling picture.

C.S. Lewis points out that to a child, who is told of the higher pleasures of life, say deep friendship, he may very well ask if there are chocolates involved. If told “no,” then he will go on to conclude that friendship is the absence of chocolate. In other words, we end up conceiving of heaven chiefly in terms of its absences.

Indeed, if we consider the unblushing promises of reward and the staggering nature of the rewards promised in the Gospels, it would seem that Our Lord finds our desires, not too strong, but too weak. We are half-hearted creatures, fooling about with drink and sex and ambition when infinite joy is offered us, like an ignorant child who wants to go on making mud pies in a slum because he cannot imagine what is meant by the offer of a holiday at the sea. We are far too easily pleased.

We must not be troubled by unbelievers when they say that this promise of reward makes the Christian life a mercenary affair. There are different kinds of reward. There is the reward which has no *natural connection* with the things you do to earn it, and is quite foreign to the desires that ought to accompany those things. Money is not the natural reward of love; that is why we call a man mercenary if he marries a woman for the sake of her money. But marriage is the proper reward for a real lover, and he is not mercenary for desiring it. ... The proper rewards are not simply tacked on to the activity for which they are given, but are the activity itself in consummation.

There is also a third case, which is more complicated. An enjoyment of Greek poetry is certainly a proper, and not a mercenary, reward for learning Greek; but only those who have reached the stage of enjoying Greek poetry can tell from their own experience that this is so. The schoolboy beginning Greek grammar cannot look forward to his adult enjoyment of Sophocles as a lover looks forward to marriage or a general to victory. He has to begin by working for marks, or to escape punishment, or to please his parents, or, at best, in the hope of a future good which he cannot at present imagine or desire. His position, therefore, bears a certain resemblance to that of the mercenary; the reward he is going to get will, in actual fact, be a natural or proper reward, but he will not know that till he has got it. Of course, he gets it gradually; enjoyment creeps in upon the mere drudgery, and nobody could point to a day or an hour when the one ceased and the other began. But it is just insofar as he approaches the reward that he becomes able to desire it for its own sake; indeed, the power of so desiring it is itself a preliminary reward.

The Christian, in relation to heaven, is in much the same position as this schoolboy. Those who have attained everlasting life in the vision of God doubtless know very well that it is no mere bribe, but the very consummation of their earthly discipleship; but we who have not yet attained it cannot know this in the same way, and cannot even begin to know it at all except by continuing to obey and finding the first reward of our obedience in our increasing power to desire the ultimate reward. Just in proportion as the desire grows, our fear lest it should be a mercenary desire will die away and finally be recognized as an absurdity. But probably this will not, for most of us, happen in a day; poetry replaces grammar, gospel replaces law, longing transforms obedience, as gradually as the tide lifts a grounded ship.¹

- C.S. Lewis, *The Weight of Glory*

Summarize the parallels between the boy making mud pies and the Christian, and the student of Greek and the Christian, with regard to heaven.

¹ Lewis, C.S. *Weight of Glory*. New York: Macmillan, 1949. pp. 26-27.

If we have not yet possessed the direct desiring of heaven, then what can we do? According to Jesus, we can start investing our treasures in heaven now.



MATTHEW 6:19–21 (ESV)

¹⁹ “Do not lay up for yourselves treasures on earth, where moth and rust destroy and where thieves break in and steal, ²⁰ but lay up for yourselves treasures in heaven, where neither moth nor rust destroys and where thieves do not break in and steal. ²¹ For where your treasure is, there your heart will be also.

What promise about our heart toward heaven does the passage above contain?



GALATIANS 6:7–8 (ESV)

⁷ Do not be deceived: God is not mocked, for whatever one sows, that will he also reap. ⁸ For the one who sows to his own flesh will from the flesh reap corruption, but the one who sows to the Spirit will from the Spirit reap eternal life.

Think about the law of sowing and reaping. What does this passage suggest regarding how we can prepare for heaven now?

WORSHIP

One of the primary activities of heaven will be worship.



REVELATION 7:9–12 (ESV)

⁹ After this I looked, and behold, a great multitude that no one could number, from every nation, from all tribes and peoples and languages, standing before the throne and before the Lamb, clothed in white robes, with palm branches in their hands, ¹⁰ and crying out with a loud voice, “Salvation belongs to our God who sits on the throne, and to the Lamb!” ¹¹ And all the angels were standing around the throne and around the elders and the four living creatures, and they fell on their faces before the throne and worshiped God, ¹² saying, “Amen! Blessing and glory and wisdom and thanksgiving and honor and power and might be to our God forever and ever! Amen.”

Think about worship—not worship services at church—but the act of worship. Think about the emotions and experience of genuinely extolling the worth of something or someone.

Describe some powerful or extraordinary experience of adoration or praise toward something other than God that you have had. What was it like?

When music lovers are moved to tears when their favorite symphony is beautifully performed; when basketball fans stand on their feet and shout praises for a perfectly executed reverse layup by their team; when a group of friends laugh uncontrollably at some secret hilarity that only they know; when a group of hikers reach a ridge and instinctively “oooh” and “aaah” as they look down on an alpine meadow beside a clear blue lake ringed by sloping granite peaks; or when spontaneous chills go down your spine as you first see the Grand Canyon or stand at the foot of Niagara Falls: these are experiences of worship. They are also experiences of bliss, and even awe, fleeting though they may be. Each of these experiences has some common features:

- ☐ There is love. The music or the lake would not bring bliss if you were tone-deaf or hated the outdoors.
- ☐ There is the absence of self-consciousness, as the thing being adored becomes the exclusive focus.
- ☐ There is also the desire to share this with others. The joy over the music, the joke, the scenery all become magnified as we are able to share it with others and show each other different aspects of its excellence as we see it. In fact, through each other, we see things we had not before, and gain a richer experience of enjoyment.
- ☐ And if you are attentive to it, there is a deep desire for timelessness. “I can sit here forever,” we may say.

Now, let’s add another picture: a mother looking at the face of her sleeping baby. Not looking, but studying, adoring, and loving. Time stands still and there is the longing of “forever” built into this scene.

Add all these up and you have a glimpse of the heavenly worship of God, whose own love, creativity, and beauty is infinitesimally reflected in these examples.

In light of this, reflect over the Revelations 7:9-12 passage once again.

We are designed for worship. We are at our truest and fullest, not when we seek adoration and try to stand out in order to gain attention, but when, in self-forgetfulness, we are caught up in the excellence of something or someone truly worthy of worship, praise and honor. Of course, we do not encounter such objects or persons on Earth, though we catch glimpses here and there. Heaven is when we finally become our fullest and truest, as we give unhindered praise unto God—praise that is undiminished by sin.

I am considering not how, but why, He makes each soul unique. If He had no use for all these differences, I do not see why He should have created more souls than one. Be sure that the ins and outs of your individuality are no mystery to Him; and one day they will no longer be a mystery to you. The mould in which a key is made would be a strange

thing, if you had never seen a key: and the key itself a strange thing if you had never seen a lock. Your soul has a curious shape because it is a hollow made to fit a particular swelling in the infinite contours of the Divine substance, or a key to unlock one of the doors in the house with many mansions. For it is not humanity in the abstract that is to be saved, but you—you, the individual reader, John Stubbs or Janet Smith. Blessed and fortunate creature, your eyes shall behold Him and not another's.

...

All that you are, sins apart, is destined, if you will let God have His good way, to utter satisfaction. Your place in heaven will seem to be made for you and you alone, because you were made for it—made for it stitch by stitch as a glove is made for a hand.

...

But it is also said 'To him that overcometh I will give a white stone, and in the stone a new name written, which no man knoweth saving he that receiveth it.' [Revelations 2:17] What can be more a man's own than this new name which even in eternity remains a secret between God and him?

And what shall we take this secrecy to mean? Surely, that each of the redeemed shall forever know and praise some one aspect of the Divine beauty better than any other creature can. Why else were individuals created, but that God, loving all infinitely, should love each differently? And this difference, so far from impairing, floods with meaning the love of all blessed creatures for one another, the communion of the saints. If all experienced God in the same way and returned Him an identical worship, the song of the Church triumphant would have no symphony, it would be like an orchestra in which all the instruments played the same note.

Aristotle has told us that a city is a unity of unlikes, and St. Paul that a body is a unity of different members. Heaven is a city, and a Body, because the blessed remain eternally different: a society, because each has something to tell all the others—fresh and ever fresh news of the 'My God' whom each finds in Him whom all praise as 'Our God'. For doubtless the continually successful, yet never complete, attempt by each soul to communicate its unique vision to all others (and that by means whereof earthly art and philosophy are but clumsy imitations) is also among the ends for which the individual was created.²

- C.S. Lewis, *Problem of Pain*

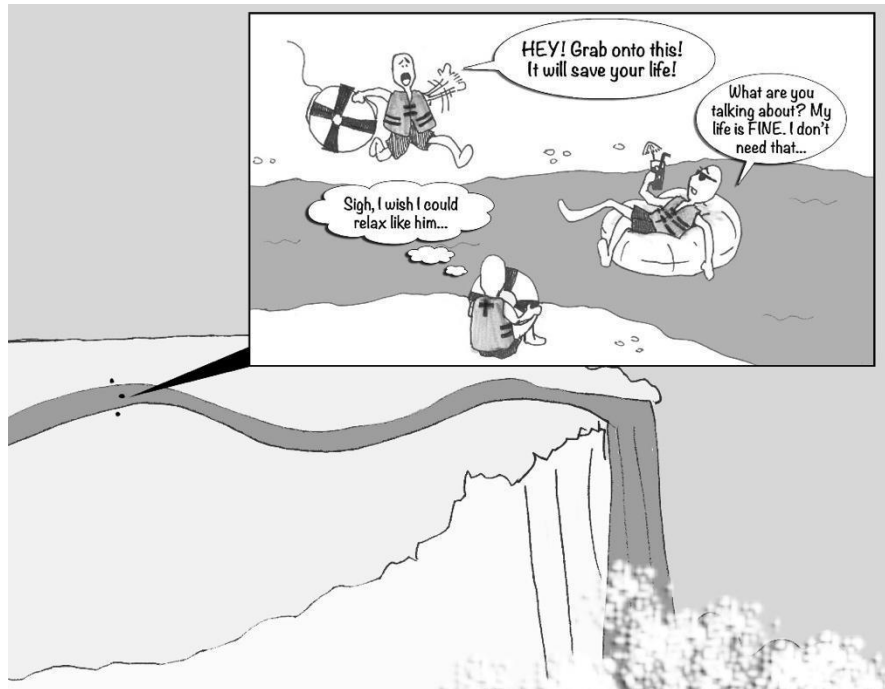
Review the C.S. Lewis passage and answer the questions below

According to C.S. Lewis, what can we look forward to in heaven? Are there ways you are experiencing a glimpse of this in your Christian life, specifically within the body of Christ?

What are some ways we can cultivate a heart of worship now?

² Lewis, C.S. *Problem of Pain*. New York: HarperCollins, 2009. Ch. 10, Location 1787. Kindle edition.

PITFALLS TO AVOID



Why would not understanding the reality of heaven and hell lead to the following?

- **Worldliness**

- **Lack of urgency towards the mission of sharing the gospel**

➤ **Envy**ing non-Christians who seem to be carefree and enjoying the world

➤ **Stinginess** towards Kingdom work/Not investing in treasures in heaven

